Case Study on Creating Reports and Dashboards for Data Visualization

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Aim

To transform stored pharmacy data into useful reports and a visual dashboard in Zoho Creator that supports daily stock and sales decisions.

Objectives

- Differentiate between list reports, summary reports and dashboards.
- Create filtered and grouped reports from one form.
- Choose suitable chart types for different questions.
- Assemble a dashboard page for the manager.

Selected Application

MediPlus Pharmacy (illustrative). The pharmacy stores medicine stock and daily sales records in Creator forms. The manager's questions are practical: which medicines will expire soon, which items are running low, and how sales are moving each week. Data alone does not answer these; reports and charts do.

Data Model

Form	Key fields
Medicine	Name, Category, Batch No, Expiry Date, Stock Quantity, Reorder Level, Unit Price
Sale	Date, Medicine (lookup), Quantity, Amount, Payment Mode, Billed By
Purchase	Date, Supplier, Medicine (lookup), Quantity, Cost

Every report is built on form records, and a list report is created automatically with each form. Several reports can be defined on one form, each with its own filter, columns and sort order.

Reports Designed

Report	Type	Filter / grouping	Question answered
All Medicines	List	None	Complete catalogue
Low Stock	List	Stock Quantity less than Reorder Level	What must be ordered?
Expiring in 60 Days	List	Expiry Date within next 60 days	What must be sold or returned first?
Sales by Category	Summary	Group by Category, sum of Amount	Which category earns most?
Sales by Payment Mode	Summary	Group by Payment Mode	Cash versus digital share
Weekly Sales	Summary / chart	Group by week	Is business growing?

Choosing Charts

Question	Best chart	Reason
Trend of sales over weeks	Line chart	Shows direction of change over time
Compare categories	Bar / column chart	Easy to compare lengths
Share of payment modes	Pie / donut chart	Parts of a whole, few categories
Single key figure (items low in stock)	KPI tile	Quick attention to one number

Building the Dashboard

A dashboard is a page that puts several reports and charts together on one canvas. For MediPlus the manager's dashboard was organised in three rows.

Row	Components
1 - Key numbers	Today's sales, Items below reorder level, Batches expiring in 60 days
2 - Trends	Weekly sales line chart, Sales by category bar chart
3 - Action lists	Low Stock report (top 10), Expiring soon report (top 10)

- Keep one question per chart and give each a clear title.
- Use consistent colours: for example red only for warnings.
- Limit the dashboard to one screen; place details behind a click on the chart.
- Apply date filters so the manager can change the period.

Sample Reading of the Dashboard (assumed data)

Observation	Decision
Antibiotics have the highest category sales	Maintain higher stock, negotiate supplier rate
12 batches expire within 60 days	Offer discount, return unsold batches to supplier
Digital payments rise week by week	Display QR code at all counters
Weekend sales are about 30% higher (assumed)	Add an extra billing staff member on weekends

Results

- Multiple reports on one form gave each user a view that matches the job.
- The dashboard shifted the manager from searching data to acting on signals.
- Choosing the chart by the question asked made the visuals easy to read.

Conclusion

Reports and dashboards turn stored records into decisions. Zoho Creator makes this possible without separate analytics tools: filters and groupings create precise reports, and the page canvas combines them into a single manager's view. The effectiveness of a dashboard, however, depends on asking the right business questions first.

Sources consulted: Zoho Creator Help documentation (forms, reports, pages, workflows, Deluge); Zoho Corporation press release on Creator AI features (April 2025) and its coverage in IT Brief; Zoho Creator Decode article on Zia-assisted Deluge (March 2026). The business scenario in this report is illustrative, and figures in it are assumed values used to demonstrate the method, not measured results.